

SECTION EIGHTEEN

THE AGENCY CHECK

Romantic fantasy stories are most powerful when characters choose each other despite everything. Not because magic forces them. Not because prophecy demands it. Not because they've got no other option. You create pressure points with your worldbuilding that offer obstacles and opportunities, but at the end of the day, your characters have to have agency.

Agency is the ability to make meaningful choices. In romance, this is everything. Your readers must believe that these two people actually want each other, not that they're biologically compelled, magically bound without consent, or politically trapped with nowhere else to go.

But here's the challenge. Romantasy has so many elements that seem to eliminate choice. Fated mates. Prophecies. Magical bonds. Arranged marriages. These tropes are popular because they provide instant stakes and force proximity, but they can accidentally strip your characters of agency if you're not careful.

This section helps you test whether your worldbuilding supports character agency or undermines it. You've already explored bonds in Section 11 (Magic & Intimacy), prophecy in Section 6 (Religion, Myth & Prophecy), and forced proximity in Section 13 (Pressure Cooker). This is where you pull all of those threads together and stress-test them. Those sections helped you design your systems. This one helps you check whether they're actually working.

A Note Before You Begin

Agency doesn't mean easy choices. Characters can face impossible situations and still have agency, as long as they're genuinely choosing rather than being compelled. **Tropes aren't inherently agency-violating.** Fated mates, magical bonds, and arranged marriages can all support agency if handled carefully. **The question isn't "are they free?" but "do they choose?"** Your characters can be constrained by circumstances and still actively choose each other within those constraints.

The Agency Paradox

In romantasy, you're usually at odds over two contradictory things:

You want: The relationship to feel destined, inevitable, cosmically significant

You also want: The characters to freely choose each other

The best romantasy makes the answer: **"Both."**

In this style of fantasy, the world pushes them together, but they still have to choose to stay. The bond is real, but they have to decide whether to accept it. The prophecy says they're meant to be, but they could still walk away. And what makes the story powerful is that they don't.

This is what separates the romances that stick with readers from the ones that feel hollow. In *A Court of Mist and Fury*, Rhysand knows about the mating bond long before Feyre does, but he never uses it to force her hand. He waits for her to come to him on her own terms, even when it costs him dearly. The bond exists, but what makes readers swoon is his choice to respect her agency within it. In *Fourth Wing*, the dragon bond between Violet and Xaden creates a telepathic link neither of them chose, but the relationship between them isn't the bond. It's what they decide to do with it, how they navigate trust and secrets and vulnerability despite the magical connection that already exists.

The most important question to ask: If you removed all external pressure, would they still choose each other?

If the answer is no, you've got an agency problem.

The Removal Tests

These tests help you figure out whether your romance depends on worldbuilding pressure or whether the connection is genuine. You explored these systems individually in earlier sections. Now strip them away, one at a time, and see what's left.

Test 1: Remove the Magic

Continue in Section 10

Magic System; Section 11 — Magic & Intimacy

If you designed bonds or intimate magic in Section 11, this is your reality check. The questions there helped you build a bond with romantic potential. The questions here test whether you've accidentally let the bond replace the romance.

What magical element connects your characters?

Identify the specific magical mechanism that links your protagonists. This is the thing you'll be stripping away to test whether the connection underneath is strong enough to stand on its own.

(Fated mate bond, telepathic link, shared magic, magical contract, curse, soul bond)

YOUR ANSWER

Without this magic, do they still have reasons to interact?

If the bond vanished tomorrow, what would keep them in each other's lives? Shared history, mutual goals, overlapping social circles, complementary skills? The stronger these non-magical reasons, the stronger your romance's foundation.

In *ACOTAR*, strip away the mating bond and Feyre and Rhysand still share the experience of Under the Mountain, a mutual understanding of trauma, and complementary values. They've got reasons to be in each other's lives that have nothing to do with magic. In *Fourth Wing*, without the dragon bond, Violet and Xaden are still cadets in a brutal military academy with a shared secret about the rebellion. The bond adds a layer, but it isn't the whole foundation.

YOUR ANSWER

Without the magic, what would still draw them to each other?

Think beyond physical attraction. What personality traits, shared experiences, or values would create a spark even without magical interference? This is the organic chemistry your romance needs underneath the bond.

YOUR ANSWER

Describe a scene from your story that would still work with the magic stripped out entirely.
If you can picture a specific moment — a conversation, a shared glance, a quiet act of care — that works without any magical enhancement, your organic connection is strong. If you're struggling to find one, magic may be doing too much of the relationship's heavy lifting.

YOUR ANSWER

Test 2: Remove the Prophecy/Destiny

Continue in Section 6

Religion, Myth & Prophecy

You explored the tension between prophecy and choice in Section 6. This test pushes that further. A prophecy that creates the relationship is always going to be weaker than one that confirms what would have happened anyway.

What prophecy or destiny element affects your romance?

Name the specific prediction, divine decree, or fated element that touches the relationship. If your story doesn't include prophecy or destiny, skip to Test 3.

YOUR ANSWER

Without the prophecy, do they still have reason to be together?

Strip the cosmic layer away. Are there personal, emotional, or situational reasons for these two to find each other? If the only answer is “the prophecy says so,” the connection needs more foundation.

YOUR ANSWER

Does prophecy create their connection, or confirm what would happen anyway?

Best answer: It confirms. They fall in love organically, and prophecy is validation, not cause. In *Twilight*, there's no prophecy at all. Edward and Bella choose each other despite every practical reason not to. His vampirism is a reason to stay apart, not a magical matchmaking mechanism. The danger is an obstacle, not a destiny.

YOUR ANSWER

Test 3: Remove the Political Pressure

Continue in Section 5

Government, Power & Law; Section 14 — Institutions

What political/institutional element forces them together?

Arranged marriage, treaty alliance, shared military unit, court obligations, hostage situation?

Identify the external structure that puts them in each other's path.

YOUR ANSWER

Without this force, would they choose to spend time together?

Imagine your characters meeting at a tavern with no political stakes. Would they be drawn to each other, or would they walk past without a second glance? The answer reveals how much your romance depends on external pressure versus personal chemistry.

YOUR ANSWER

Do they develop reasons to want to be together beyond obligation?

The strongest political romances follow a clear arc: obligation first, then genuine connection that outgrows it. In *Bridgerton* (*The Viscount Who Loved Me*), Anthony's duty to marry well and continue the family line creates the initial framework, but his connection with Kate develops entirely outside that obligation. She's the wrong sister, the inconvenient choice. When he chooses her, it's against duty, not because of it.

Good answer: They start together because they have to, and stay because they want to.

YOUR ANSWER

Test 4: Remove the Dangerous Situation

Continue in Section 1

Geography; Section 13 — Pressure Cooker

What external danger pushes them together?

War, quest, survival situation, magical threat, enemy pursuit? Name the specific threat that creates their proximity and forced reliance on each other.

YOUR ANSWER

In peacetime, with no danger, would they still connect?

Picture them in a quiet moment with nothing at stake. Do they have things to talk about? Do they enjoy each other's company when no one is trying to kill them? If the answer feels unclear, your romance might need more quiet character moments between the action beats.

YOUR ANSWER

Is their bond only about survival, or does it include genuine emotional intimacy?

Danger bonds are real, but they need more than shared adrenaline to sustain a romance past the threat. If your characters only connect when someone is trying to kill them, the relationship may feel thin once the threat passes. What emotional intimacy exists between the action beats?

YOUR ANSWER

The Goal Test

Romance characters with agency have desires independent of a romantic connection. This is one of the most common places romantasy writers accidentally undermine their protagonists: the love interest arrives, and all of a sudden the character's original goals vanish into thin air.

What does your protagonist want before the romance starts?

A concrete, specific goal that has nothing to do with a love interest. This is the desire that makes them a complete person, not just a romantic lead waiting for their match.

(Concrete goal: escape, master magic, find family, survive, defeat enemy, gain freedom, prove themselves)

YOUR ANSWER

Does this goal still matter after they meet the love interest?

Track whether the goal persists, evolves, or vanishes. If it disappears entirely, the romance may have consumed the character's identity.

If abandoned entirely: Character may have lost agency. Romance consumed their identity.

If it still matters: Good. They're a full person with their own life.

In *The Cruel Prince*, Jude wants power and belonging in the faerie world. She wants to be more than a mortal plaything. Meeting Cardan doesn't replace that drive; it complicates it. She's still fighting for her place in Elfhame even as she's falling for him. Her goal and her romance are intertwined, but neither consumes the other. In *Serpent & Dove*, Lou's goal is survival: hiding from her mother, concealing her identity as a witch while living among witch-hunters. Marrying Reid is a strategic choice, not a romantic one. Her goals don't evaporate when the romance develops; they become more complicated because falling for a man who'd kill her if he knew what she was raises the stakes on everything she's already fighting for.

YOUR ANSWER

How does the romance complicate their goal?

The best romantasy romances don't exist alongside the plot; they tangle with it. Does loving this person make the goal harder, force a choice, or change what the goal means?

Best: Romance and goal conflict, forcing hard choices.

YOUR ANSWER

Does your protagonist have to choose between their original goal and the relationship?

This is the moment that proves agency. If the protagonist never has to sacrifice or compromise anything for love, the choice doesn't carry weight.

If yes: Good. Meaningful choice demonstrates agency.

YOUR ANSWER

What does your love interest want that has nothing to do with the protagonist?

The love interest needs their own life too. A love interest whose only purpose is loving the protagonist is a prop, not a person. What drives them when the protagonist isn't in the room?

YOUR ANSWER

How does falling for the protagonist complicate those goals?

The same tension should work in both directions. If the protagonist's goals get complicated by the romance but the love interest's don't, only one of them is making real choices.

YOUR ANSWER

The “Walking Away” Question

Could your protagonist walk away from the relationship and still have a complete life?

Other goals, relationships, purposes that would sustain them? If the answer is “no, they’d have nothing,” the relationship isn’t a choice. It’s a lifeline.

YOUR ANSWER

Could your love interest walk away and still have a complete life?

Same question, other direction. Both characters need a viable life outside the romance so that choosing to stay actually means something.

YOUR ANSWER

If both answers are “yes,” then when they choose to stay, it means something. They’re choosing each other over viable alternatives.

The Choice Moment

There should be a specific moment where your characters actively choose the relationship. Not passively accept what fate decided. This is the scene readers remember. It's the moment that earns the happily ever after.

When does your protagonist actively choose the love interest?

Describe the specific scene or decision point. Not a vague feeling of "falling for them," but a moment where they make a concrete choice that commits them to this person.

(Specific scene or decision point)

YOUR ANSWER

What does this choice cost them?

A cost-free choice doesn't prove anything. The weight of what they give up is what makes the choice matter to readers.

(Safety, power, family approval, original goal, magic, freedom, identity, belonging)

If the choice costs nothing, it doesn't prove much. The weight of the choice is what makes it matter. In *ACOMAF*, Feyre choosing to return to the Spring Court to spy for Rhysand costs her safety, comfort, and honesty with the man she's falling for. It's a choice that proves she's acting with agency, not being swept along.

YOUR ANSWER

When does your love interest actively choose the protagonist?

The love interest needs a choice moment too. If only the protagonist actively chooses, the love interest is a destination, not a partner. Describe their specific scene or turning point.

YOUR ANSWER

What does this choice cost them?

What do they sacrifice, risk, or give up? The cost should be proportional to their power. A High Lord risking his court for a mortal carries different weight than a mortal risking her life for a High Lord, but both need to lose something real.

YOUR ANSWER

The “Defying the World” Moment

What worldbuilding element most strongly opposes your romance?

Look back at Section 16. Which system, law, tradition, or magical rule creates the biggest barrier between your characters? This is the force they’ll need to defy.

(Reference Section 16 — which system creates the biggest obstacle)

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a moment where your character defies this force to be with their love interest?

Describe the scene. Defiance can be loud (public declaration, breaking a law) or quiet (a whispered name, a secret meeting, a refused order). What matters is that the character acts against the world’s rules for the sake of the relationship.

YOUR ANSWER

What do they risk in this defiance?

Exile, execution, loss of magic, family rejection, war? The risk is what gives the defiance its weight. If defiance is cost-free, the worldbuilding obstacle wasn't real.

YOUR ANSWER

This defiance is proof of agency. It's your character making their own choice against the world's rules.

Making Agency Visible to Readers

While you may be aware of your character's agency while you're writing your story, readers can't rely on your knowledge of it. They need to see it demonstrated in the choices your character makes on the page. Even if you've decided how your character has chosen to act freely, unless you show that choice to the reader, they'll assume it's compulsion.

This is especially important with tropes like fated mates and magical bonds. When the bond clicks into place and the character simply... accepts it, there's no evidence they'd choose this person without it. You need to put the choice on the page.

Does the narrative show characters considering alternatives?

Describe a moment where your character thinks about another option, even briefly, before choosing the love interest. This could be considering a safer partner, imagining life alone, or weighing the cost of staying.

If they never think about other options, readers may not believe they had any. Even a brief internal moment where the character acknowledges they could walk away, could choose someone safer, could live without this person, and then chooses anyway, gives readers evidence of agency.

YOUR ANSWER

Do characters articulate their choice?

Describe a moment where they say (aloud or internally) that they're choosing this. Not "I can't help it" or "I can't stay away" (that's compulsion), but "I choose this" or "I want this, even knowing what it costs."

Check your manuscript or notes for phrases like "I can't help it," "I can't resist," "something about him made her..." or "she couldn't stay away." These are compulsion markers. If you find any in key romantic moments, can you rewrite them as active choices?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there a moment where they could leave but visibly don't?

Describe the open door they don't walk through. The exit route needs to be visible to readers, not just theoretically possible. Show the escape hatch, then show the character staying.

Showing the open door they don't walk through is one of the most effective ways to demonstrate agency on the page. In *The Cruel Prince*, Jude has multiple opportunities to leave Elfhame. She could return to the mortal world, where she'd be safe. Every time she stays, she's choosing the dangerous, painful, complicated path, and readers know it because they've seen the alternative sitting right there.

YOUR ANSWER

Do other characters acknowledge that they had a choice?

Who in your story says something like "you could have walked away" or "you didn't have to do this"? This external confirmation tells readers the choice was real, not just the character's perception.

Someone saying "you could have walked away" or "you didn't have to do this" confirms agency existed:

YOUR ANSWER

Is the cost of their choice visible on the page?

What do readers see the character lose, sacrifice, or suffer because they chose this relationship? If the cost happens offscreen or is never mentioned again, it doesn't register as real.

If choosing each other costs something, show what they lose or give up:

YOUR ANSWER

Writing Choice on the Page: Craft Techniques

Knowing your characters have agency isn't enough. To get the reader to experience it you need to show them in the way you write your story. A choice moment that works has three stages: the catalyst that forces a decision, the deliberation where the character weighs alternatives, and the commitment where they act.

The deliberation is where most writers go wrong. If a character can move from “the bond pulled her toward him” to “she was in his arms” without evidence of choice, there's no evidence she made a choice at all. The reader needs to hear the character think, even briefly. What are they giving up? What's the easier path? Why did they choose this one anyway?

Pay attention to how you construct your sentences. Agency lives in who holds the verb. Compare:

The bond pulled her toward him. She was overwhelmed by the intensity of it. Before she knew it, she was pressed against his chest.

In those sentences, the bond is the agent. The character is simply an object being acted upon by magic. Now look at this:

The bond flared, a hot tether in her chest. She gripped the back of the chair and breathed through it, waiting until the instinctual fog cleared. He was still the man who had lied to her. She weighed the lie against the roar in her blood, and chose to stay exactly where she was. “You’re going to have to do better than a magical pull,” she said.

Same bond. Same pull. But now the character is the one holding the verbs: she gripped, she breathed, she weighed, she chose, she said. The bond is something she evaluates, not something that compels her to move.

Three common prose-level mistakes that strip agency:

Filter words which create a separation between the reader and the action. “She felt drawn to him” creates a barrier between the reader and the experience. “The pull was there, insistent and warm, but she didn’t move” brings the character directly into contact with the sensation and has her choose her response.

Eliminating the deliberation entirely. If the character never thinks about other options, their actions appear as plot points instead of as choices. Even one sentence of internal weighing changes everything: *She could leave. Vivi was waiting at the border. However, if she left, she’d be abandoning the artifacts and she wasn’t done yet.*

Making the bond the subject of every sentence. When the prose continues to describe the bond’s effects for paragraph after paragraph with no character response, evaluation or resistance, the bond becomes the protagonist of the scene. Switch between describing what the bond does and what the character does about it. The character’s response is where agency lives.

A simple test: could you replace your protagonist with a lamp in a key romantic scene and have the scene play out the same way? If the love interest could interact the same way with an inanimate object, your character isn’t driving the moment.

Practise: Rewrite for Agency

You’ve just learned that agency lives in who holds the verb. Now try it with your own story. This exercise helps you feel the difference between passive and active construction before you draft your choice moment.

Write a 2–3 sentence version of a romantic moment from your story where the bond, magic, or external force is the subject of the sentences (passive version):

Example: The bond surged through her, pulling her toward him. She was helpless against the intensity. Before she could think, she was in his arms.

YOUR ANSWER

Now rewrite the same moment with your character as the subject, holding the verbs (active version):

Example: The bond flared hot in her chest. She planted her feet and waited for the fog to clear. Then she looked at him — really looked — and stepped forward because she wanted to, not because the magic told her to.

YOUR ANSWER

What changed?

Compare your two versions. In the passive version, who or what is driving the scene? In the active version, who is? Identify the specific verbs that shifted from the bond/magic to your character. This is the muscle you'll use in every romantic scene you write.

YOUR ANSWER

Audit Your Draft for Compulsion Language

Open your manuscript or outline and search for the three agency-stripping patterns described above. Finding them isn't failure — it's an opportunity to strengthen the scene. List any examples you find below so you can revise them.

Filter words (felt drawn to, was pulled toward, couldn't resist, something about him made her):

YOUR ANSWER

Missing deliberation (character jumps from trigger to action with no internal weighing):

YOUR ANSWER

Bond as subject (the bond pulled, the magic surged, the connection overwhelmed — paragraphs where the bond drives the action and the character doesn't respond):

YOUR ANSWER

Revise Your Choice Moment

Go back to the choice moment you identified earlier in this section. Using the three-stage framework (catalyst, deliberation, commitment), sketch how you'll write it on the page. This is the scene readers will remember, so it's worth getting the structure right.

The catalyst: What forces the decision right now? What makes the character unable to keep drifting?

YOUR ANSWER

The deliberation: What alternatives does your character weigh? What's the easier path they could take? What do they stand to lose by choosing the love interest?

This is where agency becomes visible. Even two or three sentences of internal weighing transforms a passive acceptance into an active choice.

YOUR ANSWER

The commitment: What action seals the choice? Not just an internal feeling, but something they do, say, or physically enact.

The best commitment moments are specific and visceral: handing someone a bowl of soup, stepping across a threshold, speaking a name they're not supposed to say, staying when the door is open.

YOUR ANSWER

The lamp test: In the scene you've just sketched, could you replace your protagonist with an inanimate object and have it play out the same way? If yes, add more deliberation or resistance.

YOUR ANSWER

The Consent Question

Magical Bonds and Consent

Continue in Section 10

Magic System, especially bonds; Section 11 — Magic & Intimacy, especially Part Two

You designed your bond mechanics in Section 11. Now it's time to test them for consent. The design questions there asked *what* the bond does and *how* it creates romantic tension. The questions here ask whether the bond respects your characters' autonomy.

Did both characters consent to this bond?

Did they choose it, agree to it, or perform a deliberate action to trigger it? Or did it happen to them without warning or input? The answer shapes how much agency work you'll need to do in the story. In *Fourth Wing*, neither Violet nor Xaden chose the telepathic link that formed through their dragons. The bond happened *to* them. What makes it work is that the story never pretends this is the same as choosing each other. The bond gives them access; trust has to be earned separately, and it's earned slowly, painfully, through choices that have nothing to do with magic.

YOUR ANSWER

If the bond formed without consent, can they reject it? What would rejection look like?

This isn't just "can they say no?" but what happens if they do. The consequences of rejection define how much agency your characters actually have. A bond that can't be rejected at all is very different from one that can be rejected at cost.

YOUR ANSWER

What would happen if they tried to reject it?

Nothing? Discomfort? Death? Loss of magic? Pain?

YOUR ANSWER

The Consent Spectrum

Highest agency: Bond can be rejected with no consequences. They choose to accept it.

High agency: Bond can be rejected at moderate cost. They weigh options and choose.

Moderate agency: Bond can be rejected at significant cost. Choice is hard but real.

Low agency: Bond can't be rejected without death or destruction. No choice about the bond, but choice remains in how they live within it.

No agency: Bond controls feelings and actions. They can't choose differently. (This is non-consensual and problematic unless the story is explicitly about breaking free.)

Where does your bond fall?

WHERE DOES YOUR BOND FALL?

If low agency, how do you preserve choice within it?

(They choose how to treat each other, whether to fight the pull, whether to act on it, what kind of relationship to build within the constraint)

Even at the “low agency” end, good romantasy finds space for choice. The bond might be unbreakable, but how they respond to it is still theirs. Do they resent it? Embrace it? Test its limits? Build something meaningful within the constraint? The relationship within the bond is where agency lives.

YOUR ANSWER

The Power Dynamic Check

Continue in Section 5

Power structures; Section 4 — Economic power

Power imbalances are simply a part of the romantic genre, and can create some of the most interesting tension in the story. The real issue lies not with the fact that a power gap exists, but rather with how well the narrative demonstrates awareness of it and provides the less powerful character with actual influence.

Mapping the Imbalance

Use the table below to map who holds what power. Seeing the imbalance side by side reveals whether one character is dangerously overpowered or whether each brings genuine leverage to the relationship.

TYPE OF POWER	LOVE INTEREST	PROTAGONIST
<i>Example: Political authority</i>	<i>High Lord of a powerful court (ACOTAR)</i>	<i>No political standing; gains it over time</i>
<i>Example: Magical ability</i>	<i>Most powerful High Lord in history</i>	<i>Unique powers from all seven courts</i>
<i>Example: Knowledge/information</i>	<i>Centuries of political knowledge</i>	<i>Mortal perspective he lacks; human resourcefulness</i>
<i>Example: Emotional leverage</i>	<i>Guarded, needs her to see him truly</i>	<i>Willing to be vulnerable first</i>

TYPE OF POWER	LOVE INTEREST	PROTAGONIST

Add more rows as needed — most romances have at least 4–5 types of power in play.

Does the power dynamic shift during the story?

A static power imbalance where the powerful character stays on top and the less powerful character never gains ground makes the romance feel like a benevolent dictatorship, not a partnership. Describe how the balance changes.

The best power-imbalanced romances don't stay static. The dynamic should shift, complicate, even reverse over the course of the story. If the powerful character starts on top and stays there, the less powerful character's agency is going to be in question.

YOUR ANSWER

The “Can They Say No?” Test

Can your protagonist say no to the love interest and have it respected? Describe a specific scene.

This is the non-negotiable test. Not “would he theoretically respect a no?” but “when has she actually said no and he’s listened?” If you can’t point to a specific moment, write one.

This is non-negotiable. If there isn’t a single moment in your story where the less powerful character refuses something and the more powerful character respects that refusal, you’ve got a consent problem, not a power dynamic.

YOUR ANSWER

If the love interest has pressured or forced the protagonist, how does the story address this?

Is it acknowledged as wrong? Are there consequences? Must they earn back trust? Or is it romanticised as “passionate”? How your story handles these moments tells readers what it believes about love and power.

YOUR ANSWER

The Captivity Scenario

Is either character literally unable to leave?

Prisoner, hostage, magically trapped, indentured? If neither character is captive, skip to “Why These Two?”

(Prisoner, hostage, magically trapped, indentured)

YOUR ANSWER

If yes, how do you maintain agency within captivity?

Even a captive character can have agency through choices about cooperation vs. resistance, mental autonomy, and the timing of when romance enters the picture. Describe the specific ways your captive character exercises choice.

(Choices about cooperation/resistance, mental autonomy, romance doesn’t begin until freedom exists or is possible, power dynamic is acknowledged and actively dismantled)

In *From Blood and Ash*, Casteel kidnaps Poppy. The story works (for readers who enjoy it) because Poppy never stops fighting. She doesn’t become passive. Her captivity is acknowledged as wrong within the narrative, and she maintains her own will, her own goals, and her own sharp tongue

throughout. She isn't tamed by captivity; she's sharpened by it. When she eventually chooses Casteel, readers believe it because they've watched her resist, question, and decide on her own terms.

YOUR ANSWER

When does the captive gain ability to leave, and what do they choose?

This is the moment that determines whether the romance is consensual. The character must gain the real ability to leave, and then choose to stay (or leave and return) for their own reasons. Describe the scene.

If they never gain this ability, the romance is fundamentally non-consensual.

YOUR ANSWER

The “Why These Two?” Test

In addition to whatever magical or political pressures exist, you’ll also need to create individualised, specific reasons why your characters have made their choices based on who they are. “The bond says so” is not a reason. “They’re both attractive” is not enough. The way your characters connect needs to be personal, unique to each character and rooted in who they are.

Use the table below to identify what makes this particular pairing work. The answers should be specific enough that they couldn’t apply to just anyone; they should only be true for these two people.

QUESTION	PROTAGONIST → LOVE INTEREST	LOVE INTEREST → PROTAGONIST
<i>What draws them to this specific person?</i>	<i>Example (ACOTAR): His willingness to sacrifice everything without asking for credit</i>	<i>Example: Her refusal to break, even when the world tried to make her</i>
<i>What does this person have that no one else has?</i>	<i>Example: He understands her darkness without flinching</i>	<i>Example: She sees past the mask everyone else believes</i>
<i>What do they see that no one else sees?</i>	<i>Example: The real Rhys — generous, funny, grieving</i>	<i>Example: A survivor who chose to fight, not just endure</i>
<i>Beyond attraction, why do they work as partners?</i>	<i>Example: Complementary strengths — her human perspective, his political knowledge</i>	<i>Example: She challenges him; he creates space for her to grow</i>
What draws them to this specific person?		
What does this person have that no one else has?		

QUESTION	PROTAGONIST → LOVE INTEREST	LOVE INTEREST → PROTAGONIST
What do they see that no one else sees?		
Beyond attraction, why do they work as partners?		

How will readers discover what makes these two unique to each other?

Pick one answer from the table above. Describe a specific scene where the reader gets to see this — not told in narration, but demonstrated through action, dialogue, or a revealing moment.

YOUR ANSWER

Much of the time, this is the core of a romantasy romance. To everyone else, your High Lord is a monster, the enemy, the prince. But your protagonist sees someone beneath that label, and is seen in return. This shared view, beyond titles and reputations, is what creates an inevitability to “why these two?”

The Alternative Path Test

There must be viable alternatives to make the choice meaningful. Simply because your protagonist doesn't have other options doesn't mean they're making a choice. It's the absence of alternatives dressed up as devotion.

What other romantic option exists for your protagonist?

Another character, choosing to be alone, a safer relationship? The alternative doesn't need to be a full love triangle, but it needs to be real enough that the reader can imagine the protagonist taking it.

(Another character, choosing to be alone, a safer/easier relationship)

YOUR ANSWER

Why do they reject this alternative?

The reason must be character-driven, rooted in who they are and what they want. "The bond says so" or "because he's the male lead" isn't a reason. What specifically about the love interest makes the protagonist choose the harder path?

(Must be a character-driven reason, not just "the bond says so")

YOUR ANSWER

What other option exists for your love interest?

Same question from the other side. Could they choose someone easier, less complicated, more politically convenient? What's the path of least resistance they're rejecting?

YOUR ANSWER

Why do they reject it?

Again, character-driven. What does the protagonist offer that no easier option can match? What need does the protagonist fulfil that a simpler choice wouldn't?

YOUR ANSWER

Is there an easier, safer option than being together?

If yes: Good. Choosing the harder path demonstrates agency and commitment.

YOUR ANSWER

Agency in the Ending

Ultimately, the final decision should be made actively by the characters, rather than arriving at it passively. After all the obstacles, all the worldbuilding pressure, all the forces working to bring them together or pull them apart, the last act of the story must include a clear and active decision.

Do your characters shape their own ending, or does the plot deliver it to them?

Describe the specific decision one or both characters make in the final act that seals their commitment. Not just “the villain is defeated and now they’re together” but an active choice. If the ending feels granted (the curse just lifted, the prophecy completed itself, the villain conveniently died) rather than earned, look for a place to insert a final choice — even if external forces resolve the plot, the relationship resolution should come from the characters themselves.

YOUR ANSWER

If the characters had chosen differently, how would the ending change?

Describe the alternate ending that was possible. If you can’t imagine a different outcome regardless of their choices, they didn’t have meaningful agency in the resolution.

YOUR ANSWER

What does this final choice cost them, and how do readers see it?

The cost is what makes the earned ending feel earned. What do they sacrifice, risk, or give up in this final moment? If the cost happens offscreen or is never mentioned again, it doesn't register as real.

YOUR ANSWER

Agency in Cultural Context

What agency looks like depends on the world you've built.

Continue in Section 3

Culture; Section 5 — Government

While some worlds offer greater freedom than others, that doesn't mean there's anything wrong with your worldbuilding. When you have a rigidly hierarchical society where your protagonist chooses to refer to their love interest by their first name rather than their title, that too is a form of defiance just as powerful as any dramatic declaration in a freer world. The key is developing agency consistent with your setting.

In your world, how much choice do people typically have about their lives and relationships?

This establishes the baseline. In a world where everyone chooses their own partner, a love match isn't rebellious. In a world where marriages are arranged by family elders, choosing your own partner is revolution.

YOUR ANSWER

Is having any choice at all radical in your setting?

In highly controlled societies, small acts of choice carry enormous weight. In *From Blood and Ash*, Poppy removing her veil is a radical act in a world where the Maiden must remain unseen. It's a tiny gesture by our standards, but it's an assertion of selfhood in a world designed to erase it.

YOUR ANSWER

What does choosing each other mean within your world's context?

Describe the specific consequences of their choice in your setting. Are they breaking a law, defying a tradition, starting a war, losing their family, or simply doing something unusual? The consequences define the weight of the choice.

In some worlds, refusing an arranged marriage is revolutionary. In others, it's ordinary.

YOUR ANSWER

Are your characters' acts of agency appropriately weighted for your world?

A grand public declaration in an oppressive world might get them killed. A quiet private choice in a free world might go unnoticed. Make sure the scale of their defiance matches the scale of their world's restrictions.

Small choices in oppressive worlds can be as powerful as dramatic choices in free ones.

YOUR ANSWER

Do readers from our world need context to understand why their choices matter?

If your world restricts choice in ways that modern readers might not immediately understand, you'll need to show the consequences for others who've defied the system. Readers need to see what's at stake before the protagonist risks it.

If choice is rare in your world, make sure readers understand what choosing costs. You can't assume they'll automatically grasp the weight of a small rebellion unless you've shown them what the consequences look like for people who defy the system.

YOUR ANSWER

Who in your world has defied the system before your protagonist, and what happened to them?

This is how you show readers the stakes. A character who chose their own partner and was exiled, a couple who defied tradition and were separated, a rebel who was executed — these precedents tell readers what your protagonist is risking before they risk it. Name the example your story will use.

YOUR ANSWER

The Compulsion Spectrum: Deciding What Your Bond Does

You can't repair anything unless you know what you're trying to fix. Every romantasy romance has its own degree of agency, and not every reader wants the same thing. Readers of fated mate stories buy these books because they want the attraction, the inevitability, the cosmic affirmation that these two belong together. The issue isn't about including compulsion in your work. It's about how much, and how your characters react to it.

Your romantic bond will fall somewhere along this spectrum:

Full compulsion: The bond is irresistible. The characters may use reason and logic but ultimately, they can't stay away from each other. This type of romantic relationship is raw, instinctual, and physically intense. Readers get to watch as characters fight a losing battle against something larger than themselves, which makes the romance satisfying. Because full compulsion leaves very little room for agency, the characters need strong identities and goals outside the bond to keep them from feeling like puppets. This style of romance is often found in darker romantasy and enemies-to-lovers, where the tension arises from not wanting to desire someone.

Choice within fate: The bond indicates a possible match, however the characters still have to develop the relationship. In essence, fate brought them together, and now they get to decide if they wish to remain together. This is the most popular approach in romantasy currently because it offers the reader the inevitable connection that feels like fate, along with the emotional connection that develops as the characters interact. In *ACOMAF*, the mating bond is real, but Rhysand delays its revelation until months later so Feyre can select him for who he is, not because the Cauldron said so. The bond verifies what has been developing. This method works best when the heroine's ability to make choices autonomously is central to the story.

Fate as conflict: The bond is a hindrance, an obstacle, or even a curse. The characters are actively working against the predestination. This creates the greatest amount of angst possible and presents a platform for characters to demonstrate which judgement they value more: their own, or that of the gods. In *Zodiac Academy*, Tory Vega rejects her Elysian Mate bond with Darius Acrux during the "Divine Moment" beneath the stars, and does so knowing it will curse her to never find love again. She says no because he bullied her, because she will not allow magic to erase what he did. The stars confirm they're mates, but she chooses her own dignity over the cosmic reward. Her decision to reject the mating bond is one of the most discussed agency moments in the genre. This approach works best

Which does your target reader want?

Some readers may enjoy the idea of a “safe harbour,” the sense of knowing that this person belongs to them permanently and irrevocably. Other readers are looking for the “defiant stand” of agency: a heroine who gets her love through her own choices, rather than the choices of fate. Ultimately, most readers would like to see both elements, which is why the middle of the spectrum tends to be the most popular. Understand your audience and you can then develop your worldbuilding around their desires.

YOUR ANSWER

Look back at your answers in the Removal Tests. Given where your bond sits on the spectrum, which test result concerns you most?

A “full compulsion” bond needs exceptionally strong non-magical reasons for the relationship (Test 1). A “choice within fate” bond needs a clear acceptance moment. A “fate as conflict” bond needs visible resistance. Which of your earlier answers feels weakest given your spectrum position?

YOUR ANSWER

Your Agency Action Plan

Based on where your bond sits on the spectrum, identify the specific agency work your story needs. Different positions require different solutions.

YOUR SPECTRUM POSITION	WHAT YOUR STORY NEEDS MOST	YOUR SPECIFIC PLAN
<i>Example: Choice within fate</i>	<i>A clear acceptance moment where the character consciously chooses the bond</i>	<i>A food-offering scene in Chapter 18 where she decides after hearing his explanation — modelled on the ACOMAF soup scene</i>

The Acceptance Ritual

One of the best ways to provide agency within an otherwise fated bond is to create a specific, voluntary act as part of your worldbuilding that “seals” the bond. This allows the bond to transition from something that has happened to the characters to something they actively chose to do.

In *ACOMAF*, Maas creates this type of voluntary act as a cultural tradition: a female offering food to her mate. During the famous soup scene, Feyre is heating a bowl of soup while Rhysand shares with her his side of the story. Feyre has clearly made the offer conditional on whether she wants to give it to him, and only does so after he finishes talking. It’s then a deliberate decision to accept the bond based on the understanding that was provided beforehand. The romantic satisfaction comes from Rhysand’s years of devotion; the agency comes from Feyre’s unwillingness to accept it until she understands the full context of what was going on.

In *Zodiac Academy*, the “Divine Moment” is accepted as an active decision by each participant under the stars. In *From Blood and Ash*, the “Joining” is a ritual that requires each of the parties to actively agree, thus broadening the definition of bonds to include more than just a couple.

Does your world have a ritual, action, or declaration that “seals” the bond?

If yes, describe it. If no, consider creating one. An acceptance ritual is one of the simplest, most effective ways to add a visible moment of choice to a fated bond.

YOUR ANSWER

Does this action require conscious choice?

If the bond simply snaps into place with no input from the characters, look for a way to add a moment of acceptance. Even a small one, like a spoken vow, an offered hand, or a deliberate step forward, gives the characters (and the readers) a visible moment of choice.

YOUR ANSWER

The Agency Repair Kit

If your removal tests or checklist revealed problems, here's where to fix them. Each repair preserves the trope while restoring character choice.

If the Magical Bond Is Doing Too Much

- **Add friction:** Even with a bond, they don't automatically like each other. They have to choose to work with it. The bond in *ACOTAR* creates pull, but Feyre and Rhysand still have to navigate trust, communication, and the messy reality of two complicated people learning to be together.
- **Delay the reveal:** Have one character know about the bond first and choose to hide it so the other can develop genuine feelings without magical pressure. This is the Rhysand model: he waits because he values Feyre's autonomy more than his own desire to claim the bond.
- **Add cost to acceptance:** Accepting the bond means giving something up. The choice has weight.
- **Build an acceptance ritual:** Create a specific, voluntary action that seals the bond (a vow, an offering, a ritual) so the bond isn't complete until both characters choose it.
- **Show choosing within the bond:** They control whether to act on it, how they treat each other, what kind of relationship they build.

If Prophecy Is Removing Agency

- **Make it vague:** Prophecy says they're connected but not how or what it means.
- **Make it resistible:** They can fight it. Maybe it's even wrong. Prophecy is suggestion, not command.
- **Make it a late reveal:** They fall in love first, then discover prophecy validates what already happened.

If Political Pressure Is Removing Agency

- **Give them the option to escape, and show them choosing to stay** for their own reasons. The exit door needs to be visible so that staying is clearly a choice.
- **Show them making the arrangement meaningful:** It started political; they chose to make it real.
- **Add genuine choice within the forced situation:** How they treat each other is still their choice.

If Power Imbalance Is Removing Agency

- **Give the less powerful character leverage** that's something the powerful one needs. Not charity from above, but genuine power the protagonist earns or possesses independently.
- **Show the powerful character restraining their power** by choosing not to use it. In *ACOMAF*, Rhysand has the power to compel Feyre through their bargain, but he consistently chooses not to. His restraint is a form of respect that readers recognise.
- **Address the imbalance explicitly:** Characters acknowledge it and actively work to create equality.

If the Dangerous Situation Is the Only Glue

- **Build emotional intimacy between action beats.** Don't let every conversation be about strategy or survival. Give them quiet moments where they connect as people, not just allies.
- **Show them choosing connection when survival doesn't require it.** If they only interact when danger forces it, the relationship will feel transactional.
- **Plant a peacetime moment.** Even a brief scene where they imagine or experience life without danger, and still want to be together, proves the connection runs deeper than adrenaline.

Revise Your Agency

Look back at your answers throughout this section. If the removal tests, consent check, or power dynamic assessment revealed weak spots, use the repair suggestions above to strengthen them. Write your specific planned changes below.

Which repair category applies to your story?

(Magical bond / Prophecy / Political pressure / Power imbalance / Dangerous situation / More than one)

YOUR ANSWER

What specific change will you make to strengthen agency?

Be concrete. Not “I’ll add more choice” but “I’ll add a scene in Chapter 12 where she has the chance to leave and chooses to stay because...”

YOUR ANSWER

How will this change affect the romantic arc?

Agency repairs often strengthen the romance rather than weakening it. Describe how giving your character more choice will make the eventual commitment more meaningful.

YOUR ANSWER

Integration Check: Does Your Agency Hold Up?

This section pulled from nearly every earlier section in the workbook. Use this table to verify your agency answers are consistent with what you've already built.

EARLIER SECTION	WHAT YOU BUILT THERE	DOES IT SUPPORT AGENCY HERE?	IF NOT, WHAT NEEDS TO CHANGE?
<i>Example: Section 6 — Prophecy</i>	<i>A prophecy that the “star-born heir” would unite two kingdoms through love</i>	<i>Partially — it confirms but also creates pressure</i>	<i>Make the prophecy vaguer so it's not a matchmaking decree</i>
Section 6 — Religion, Myth & Prophecy			
Section 10 — Magic System			
Section 11 — Magic & Intimacy			
Section 13 — Pressure Cooker			

EARLIER SECTION	WHAT YOU BUILT THERE	DOES IT SUPPORT AGENCY HERE?	IF NOT, WHAT NEEDS TO CHANGE?
Section 5 — Government, Power & Law			
Section 14 — Institutions			
Section 16 — Obstacle Map			

The Agency Checklist

For strong character agency, you should be able to check most of these:

- ☐ If I removed all magical bonds/prophecy, they'd still be attracted to each other
- ☐ Both characters have goals and identity outside the romance
- ☐ There's a specific moment where each actively chooses the other
- ☐ This choice costs them something significant
- ☐ Both characters can (and do) say "no" to each other and have it respected
- ☐ The less powerful character has meaningful agency within the power dynamic
- ☐ They have reasons to choose each other beyond "fate says so"
- ☐ Both resist the relationship at some point before choosing it
- ☐ Alternatives exist that they consciously reject
- ☐ Readers can see the choice on the page (not just author intention)
- ☐ The ending is shaped by their choices, not delivered by plot convenience

Score:

8-11 checked: Strong agency. Your characters are genuinely choosing each other.

5-7 checked: Moderate. Some elements need strengthening.

0-4 checked: Agency problems. Your worldbuilding may be overriding genuine choice.

Quick Reference: Agency Essentials

The bond/pressure that brings them together:

THE BOND/PRESSURE THAT BRINGS THEM TOGETHER:

Why they'd choose each other without it:

WHY THEY'D CHOOSE EACH OTHER WITHOUT IT:

The moment protagonist actively chooses:

THE MOMENT PROTAGONIST ACTIVELY CHOOSES:

The moment love interest actively chooses:

THE MOMENT LOVE INTEREST ACTIVELY CHOOSES:

What each choice costs:

WHAT EACH CHOICE COSTS:

The alternative they reject:

THE ALTERNATIVE THEY REJECT:

How power imbalance is addressed:

HOW POWER IMBALANCE IS ADDRESSED:

Final Thought: Choice Is What Makes It Love

Magic can bring them together. Prophecy can suggest they're meant to be. Political pressure can force proximity. Danger can create intimacy.

But in the end of the story, they need to choose each other freely. They'll have to decide despite the costs, despite the alternatives, despite the easier paths available, because of who they are and what they've discovered in each other.

That choice is what makes the romance feel earned.

That choice is what separates "they ended up together" from "they chose each other."

That choice is what makes it love.